

GAMING AS CONTROL: WILL TO POWER, THE PRISON OF DEBATE AND GAME CALLED POTLATCH

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*There are two types of prisons some say. One where you're
locked up and everything is outside, and another where you're
outside, and everything is locked away.*

- The Broadways "Upton"

Debate paradigms are boundaries drawn to include and exclude certain types of behavior. At their most mundane, debate paradigms establish the "rules" that encircle the activity of debating. Because paradigms become hinging points for understanding how debate works, advocates for various paradigms don't simply interpret debate, but position some activities as debate, and others as not-debate. Alfred "Tuna" Snider's gaming paradigm was an important shift because it positioned debate as a "big tent" where all other paradigms could be understood (e.g., Snider, 1982).

Snider's gaming provided a cogent explanation of how debate worked. Specifically, he articulated a meta-theory that included all other paradigms and provided space for most changes. In fact, gaming has been a vital tool in the defense of culture changers. In the 1980s debaters used gaming to defend speaking quickly in debates. Many of the argumentation techniques (including using plans in traditional CEDA debate) were framed within gaming (Snider, 1984). Gaming gave us a clear explanation of the paradigm of debate, and helped to encourage change within the debate community.

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Despite the positive impact of Snider's work on the debate community, this essay articulates a criticism of gaming. While innovative and transformative, gaming is also another form of boundary drawing, one whose explanatory value comes with a price. Criticism of Snider's work only returns us to the central question of what kind of framework is valuable for debate. In this essay I turn to a particular game called the potlatch, a game that shatters all previous structures.

While gaming is positive and valuable for participants in debate circles, it encourages us to turn our attention and love back to the circle of debate. This essay seeks to agitate the gamers, and push them to look beyond the game and consider breaking even the most solid of rules.

Snider: Gaming as Emancipatory

Snider's writings on Gaming were a significant move forward in the dialogue about debate paradigms. Previous paradigms had been blatant attempts to keep barbarians away from the sacred space of debate, or were transparent efforts to justify competitive inequity. Gaming was revolutionary because it followed the clear lines of Thomas Kuhn – focusing on theories as valuable because they *explain* our world (Snider 1982, 1984). Unlike policy-making, or hypothesis testing, Gaming didn't advocate for a position on paradigms; it explained all the other paradigms as gamers arguing to change rules for competitive advantages. Along the way, as Snider points out in his essay in this collection, gaming helps to understand and encourage change within the debate community.

Reality Check: Gaming as Control

Despite Snider's intentions to explain why paradigms worked in debate, the actual value of gaming is questionable. Paradigms were potent because they included and excluded – Snider's version of the world theoretically, included everyone. One must wonder what the explicatory value of gaming really is, if it tells us that debate is "us"? The answer of course, is that gaming did much more than just explain paradigms. It also argued for a vision of debate, one that has become increasingly popular among college policy debaters.

Snider's big-tent vision of debate is a relatively recent turn in the gaming literature. Early versions of gaming were vigorous defenses of "new debate" complete with fast-talking and innovative arguments (Snider, 1984). Gaming was the paradigm for debaters-first advocates. Because gaming framed everything in terms of competition, the quest for new tactics, strategies, arguments, and literature were obvious outgrowths of competitors at work. Gaming was the paradigm of change in debate, because it didn't stake out a model, it modeled the stakes.

In chapter five of his dissertation, titled "Gaming and the 'Excesses' of the 'New' Debate," Snider quotes argumentation theorist Wayne Brockriede, who juxtaposes a college debater with an activist "outside the classroom building" who is debating on a microphone and advocates seizing the administration building. Snider's final word on the question of praxis is "debate need not imitate all it sees in the 'real world,' it merely has to be part of that reality in and of itself" (Snider, 1984, p. 216). Snider's early work was a vigorous defense of non-applied communication work. He argued firmly and correctly, that debate oratory need not be modeled on "real life" communication needs. Speaking quickly and using jargon were defensible practices under a paradigm of gaming.

Juxtapose these claims with Snider's 2003 advocacy of gaming. In this essay, Snider describes a token multicultural buffet as one of the benefits of gaming. "Debate can be thought of as our intellectual food, and there are a delightful variety of ways to serve debate just as there are to serve food." Snider's diverse vision includes all of the formats of debate in vigorous dialogue – but not much revolutionary potential. This prose is emblematic of the *We Are the World* approach that encourages well-intentioned surface level change.¹

Snider's new gaming advocacy is a laundry list of positive changes in the policy debate community. Snider positions himself and his theoretical work in

¹ It is important to recognize that Snider himself has been at the vanguards of many changes in debate. He has passionately advocated for the inclusion of many in policy debate, advocated for cultural change, and has been a strong leader in the debate community. My criticisms here are of gaming, not of Snider.

the arms of debaters using critical theory in debate arguments, Urban Debate Leagues, debate across the curriculum, and international debate. These are all wonderful changes in debate, but we must ask how much impact gaming has had on their development? The answer is that Snider has been central in most of these struggles, and gaming has been touted as part of these struggles, but gaming itself has not created significant change. But let us not mistake Snider's involvement with the value of his theory in leveraging change. Let us focus our attention explicitly on the importance of gaming in these changes.

The big question is: does gaming contribute to these revolutionary format changes? I will answer no. Rather, I would like to position gaming as a controlling force. Gaming is a challenging, innovative, and adaptable theory but, fundamentally, a theory of control. Gaming works as an answer to the question of what debates do. But while we can answer that we play a game (albeit a serious and complex one), we also say something about the players and why we play the game. Gaming became a tool for control – convincing debaters that energies of criticism should be reinvested into the debate community. The very parameters of Snider's goals, to encourage more participants in debate, belie a rigged question. We are intended to succeed through gaming to bring a few other voices into debate. But like the plus-one activist struggle that simply seeks representation, this approach is doomed to failure.

We should not be surprised that the traditional agents of social control have a brilliant new theory that encourages limited change. Gaming in fact operates to metastasize the crisis-politics of modern policy debate, covering over the rotting corpse with a sweet perfume. For example, gaming minimizes and cripples the increasing tension over activist-oriented arguments in debate rounds. Gaming encourages such argument innovation not for the world community but for the debate community, teaching students to passionately plead for change to an empty room. How can a theory understand the desire of debaters to crack open the debate methods and introduce something "outside" of debate as Snider points to in his most recent gaming essay? The answer is that it can't. Debate as a model can only create more debate, and so long as our goal for debate is more debate, then we will never emerge to challenge larger forces of control.

Worse than being satisfied with shouting at walls, approaching debate from the perspective of games encourages a god-complex that teaches debaters that saying something poignant in a debate round translates into something larger in the world.

Christopher Douglas, a professor of English at Furman University, explores how games teach us to adore the replay: “This is the experience structured into the gaming process—the multiple tries at the same space-time moment. Like Superman after Lois Lane dies, we can in a sense turn back the clock and replay the challenge, to a better end” (2002, p. 7). What kind of academic activity encourages students to fantasize about making change without considering for the slightest bit how to bring that change about?

Douglas positions this impulse alongside the Sisyphean burden of trying to make the world into a structured, controlled, sterile environment. Sisyphus and the reset button on a videogame console share a common ancestor with the debate model that has thirty debate teams advocating different policies in separate rooms at exactly the same time. All of these examples showcase humans desperately attempting to construct meaning out of a confusing world, where the human *will to power* forces the world to fit a structure. Douglas reminds us that games help to structure an oft-confusing world, imbuing the person imagining with god-like powers (McGuire, 1980; Nietzsche 1966):

Games therefore do not threaten film’s status so much as they threaten religion, because they perform the same existentially soothing task as religion. They proffer a world of meaning, in which we not only have a task to perform, but a world that is made with us in mind. And indeed, the game world is made with us, or at least our avatar in mind. (Douglas, 2002, p. 9)

Gaming draws forth a natural impulse of humans – to make the world in our image. But debate and videogames contain the same fantastic lure that encourages people to pore their energies into debate. Fiat and utopian flights of fancy are both seductions of our will to power, encouraging us to commit to becoming better debaters.

This process of self-important distraction has its model in the theories of the hyper-real posited by Jean Baudrillard. He argues that modern economies are

geared to sell humans mass produced products, but whose advertising attempts to convince people that they have an authentic experience with the product.

Economic structures make products that are more-than real – hyperreal in order to sell their products. The hyperreal creates games and fantasylands that are far richer and pleasurable than real life. One example of the hyperreal is Epcott center at Disneyland, which reduces foreign cultures to their most base natures – ensuring that everything is uniform, bland, and suitably “ethnic.”

While one never need worry about eating food that is “too strange” in the Epcott lands, other negatives emerge in the world of the hyperreal. Humans who desire order and structure to our worlds often come to prefer the hyperreal to the real. The hyperreal has a world with all of the attractions of our own, but with none of the depressing realities of our own world. The hyperreal doesn’t have credit card bills or racism. The hyperreal is filled with beautiful people (who all want to have sex with you). The hyperreal is a hot seduction pulling our vision and hearing away from our own lives.

Describing Snider’s gaming as a dangerous distraction that pulls us away from our communities and our lives is a bit simplistic. Rather, gaming greases the wheels for powers of control to remain in control. Douglas articulates some of the specific ways games solidify structures of power.

In board games or computer games, however, players actually do start out in relative equality (although there are some chance elements as well, depending on the game), whereas in real life, so many characteristic of one’s life are already determined before birth, including social and economic standing, political freedom, skin color, gender, etc. What games accomplish is the instilling of the ideology of equality, which postulates that we are born equal and that differences emerge later on; the primary different to be explained away in this way is that of economic disparity, and games help explain that difference as the result of, in America, hard work and effort vs. laziness. Thus gaming helps inculcate the ideology that covers over the fact that, with the exception of the information technology bubble, most of those who are wealthy in the United States were born that way. Beyond this narrow ideological function, the game helps create subjects that accept the inevitability of rules as things that are given and must be “played” within—

or else there is no game. This process is not total or ever complete, as the current gaming discourse complaining about the rules shows; here, player critique a game's rules in view of a conventionalized notion of how "reality" works, or, less often, how a game's playability is compromised by rules that are too "realistic (Douglas, 2002, p. 24).

Viewing debate as a game may have the opposite effect that Snider desires. Gaming teaches participants to play by the rules and even when challenging the game, to do that within the game's structures. Debaters who are moved by poetry are encouraged to bring that poetry back to the debate realm – not to become poets.²

There are certainly debate-activists who bring their debate skills to bear on the political community. These debaters seamlessly slide between academic hyperbole in the First Affirmative Constructive and talking to homeless folks at a Food Not Bombs meal. But these folks are few and far between. Most who hear the call to conscience turn their backs on the call and justify their (in) actions by valorizing debate.³

Let me be clear that the desire of individuals to make the world is not the enemy. It is a positive drive that encourages debaters to fiat worlds into existence or hypothesizes that the world would be good if George Bush were before the International Criminal Court on charges of crimes against humanity. This drive to create a better world *is* the will to power. The big question is, what we do with that will to power? Recognizing that there are many complex problems in the world that require smart articulate people to solve them, we can appreciate the

² There are some debaters who have become exceptionally good at meshing poetry with competitive debate. I would point out Nader Hadad from Cal State Long Beach and Lana Langsweirdt from the University of Vermont as debaters who have both become powerful poets and good debaters (who use poetry in their rounds).

³ For more on this see Gordon Mitchell's (1998) article on the pedagogy of public debates. He outlines a number of debate initiatives that have used public debate outside of the policy debate realm.

potential value of will to power (McGuire, 1980). In the debate context, will to power becomes reified in a hyper-real role-playing exercise.

Debate can be an amazing experience where students learn about complex ideas and then take those ideas into their own lives and communities. Debate can be a method for learning that people have their own voices in a world drowning with mediated/televised slime-balls. Debate can encourage intellectual growth and cause epiphanies. Debate encourages solidarity and teaches people to struggle together. Debate is primed to be a blast furnace for the will to power and take it to the furthest level of revolutionary potential. The only limitation is our own. If we frame debate to limit the revolutionary potential of the participants, then we do a disservice not only to our students, but also to the world.

Nietzschean will to power is a drive for self-overcoming, transforming fuel for personal and collective change.⁴ Will to power exists in all of us as a lunging to escape our current world and create another beyond the moral structure and hierarchy of this world. This desire to create a better world is admirable and is at the root of social change. My criticism of gaming is that this energy is sublimated into a fantasy world rather than being brought to the larger world. But perhaps there is a kind of game that might elicit something of what I desire . . . from within debate.

The Real Game: Potlatch

As pointed out in the last section, the stakes for the game of debate are high. The method of debate contains the possibility for revolutionary insight and revolutionary praxis. The question is how to understand an activity without systematizing and controlling the potential of debate. What we really must do is let free the will to power within debaters. In this sense, we can use gaming as the topoi to launch our conversation to a debate game that might encourage revolution.

⁴ Gilles Deleuze (1983) writes about Nietzsche's unique take on the will to power. "The will to power alone is the one that wills, it does not lend itself be delegated or alienated to another subject, even to force" (p. 49).

But what does will to power look like? How do we encourage it? Lets get a feeling from George Bataille, who orients the Nietzschean impulse of will to power alongside a quote from Nietzsche himself:

Through the shutters into my window comes an infinite wind, carrying with it unleashed struggles, raging disasters of the ages. And don't I too carry within me a blood rage, a blindness satisfied by the hunger to mete out blows? How I would enjoy being a pure snarl of hatred, demanding death: the upshot being no prettier than two dogs going at it tooth and nail! Though I am tired and feverish..."Now the air all around is alive with the heat, earth breathing a fiery breath. Now everyone walks naked, the good and bad, side by side. And for those in love with knowledge, it's a celebration." (Nietzsche, 1968, p. 4)

Will to power can be the outgrowth of debate that challenges existing structures. Bataille and Nietzsche desire a wild emancipation from traditional structures, far beyond conventional morality. Coupling Nietzsche's theorizing with the practice of debate something new can emerge, but only if we free ourselves from the shackles of conventional debate, including gaming. How to break these chains? How do we get beyond that which has brought us so far? To help, I want to turn to Guy Debord and the Situationists.

Guy Debord was a French revolutionary whose political theorizing and activism culminated in the creation first of the Letterist International and later in the establishment of the Situationist International. The Letterists/Situationists were revolutionary philosophers who believed that the situations of the modern world were increasingly controlled by mediated/corporate experience. They viewed traditional politics in all of its reformist formats as a waste of time. Through a variety of situations (manipulated by the situationists) it was possible to create revolutionary meaning. They used a variety of tactics in order to elicit revolutionary change. Some of their methods, like detournement, have become common post-modern critical theory concepts.⁵

⁵ Detournement is most well known from the Canadian magazine Adbusters, who re-popularized Debord's work in the 1990s doing mock-ups of popular advertisements.

I focus our attention on the Situationists because they succeeded in creating a revolution. Situationist propaganda and theorizing were at the heart of the Parisian rebellion of May of 1968. This was the most powerful expression of malaise against the increasingly wealthy industrial western world. The riots in Paris, which upended cars and collectives emerged in downtown, became a model for revolutions in the industrialized north. Debord was seen as an intellectual architect of the uprising of students and workers. Situationists/Letterists were increasingly capable of articulate criticisms of the nature of the spectacle. These were often told through journals, graffiti, and posters (Dark Star Collective, 2001; Debord, 1995; Jappe, 1992; Hussey, 2001).

One of the most important Situationist tactics was articulated in the potlatch. The potlatch was a practice modeled on American indigenous communities of increasingly committed giving. In the potlatch, indigenous would give everything they had to each other, ever increasing the stakes of the gifts until the gifts were so outlandish the offers exposed the foolish nature of ownership. Potlatch became so important to these revolutionaries that they named their first journal potlatch because the writings held within the journal would hopefully be given on and on in an ever increasing spiral. Potlatch became an extended metaphor for the Situationists/Letterists, indicating all the possible spaces where revolution could emerge without capitalist economies. Every non-capitalist moment eked out of the day was articulated as a potlatch. Every relationship that emerged along side revolutionary dialogue became a potlatch. In a recent biography of Debord and the situationists, the author Hussey describes the Potlatch.

Potlatch... is the highest form of game. It is also the living moment of poetry, a moment which breaks down or reverses conventional chronological patterns. Most significantly, the object or gift which the Letterist International gave functioned symbolically between the giver, the International Letterists, and the receiver. The relationship between the two constitutes a third term – the gift is also a catalyst of the future in the form of a crystallization of desire. ‘Don’t collect Potlatch!’ ran a line at the end of the journals second year. “Time is working against you!” (Hussey, 2001, p. 89)

For the Situationists, the potlatch was the ultimate resistance to traditional economies. Originally a concept theorized by George Battaille, the potlatch was seen as a method to criticize the acquisition/showcase methods of modern capitalist economies. Because the potlatch could never be returned, it highlighted the foolishness of the modern economy and state. Through sacrifice and destruction, the act of giving overwhelms the possible response. Eventually, the social requirements of the potlatch necessitate that every society member give away everything they could ever have.

Yet we should not move too far from the fundamental truth of the potlatch: it is in fact a game. Indigenous nations would choose to exchange gifts in the potlatch as a form of entertainment. But let us not understate the importance of games. This game was made illegal because it was so dangerous to colonial economies. The Potlatch was recognized as threatening the burgeoning trading economy that was central to westward expansion. The potlatch was the most dangerous idea that indigenous nations could forward against the white/capitalist drive.⁶

The act of giving too much was the threat. This move disturbed the intense drive for acquisition. Why fight to trade beaver pelt, when at the next potlatch

⁶ In my theorizing about this essay, I contemplated including a reference to Ernest Callenbach's novel *Ecotopia*. In this novel, Callenbach's protagonist enters a closed off zone of ecologically sustainable territories in the Pacific Northwest of the former-USA. One of the most hotly contested differences between the protagonist and the Ecotopians is a game. The Ecotopians use ritual physical combat to explore the visceral experience that is part of humans. Young men will gather and fight each other with spears. It seems as though there is a good comparison between my proposal of the potlatch and Callenbach's war games. Both are visceral games that are intended to alter the state of the participants. In *Ecotopia*, the war game is the turning point of the book, where the protagonist, torn between two worlds appreciates the Ecotopian world and begins to consider living in *Ecotopia*. I would hope that my reference to the potlatch would have a similar affect.

your neighbor might give you all her possessions? Potlatch was threatening because it made competition meaningless.

Non-competitive social structure was only one threat from the Potlatch. Situationist biographer Jappe discovers an obscure quotation by Debord on the Potlatch (Debord himself was remarkably close-lipped about the meaning of Potlatch): “Debord refers explicitly to the Indian custom of Potlatch and announces that ‘the non-saleable goods that a free bulletin such as this is able to distribute are novel desires and problems; and only the further elaboration of these by others can constitute the corresponding return gift’” (p. 148). What was exchanged in Debord’s vision was not necessarily goods but rather ideas.⁷

Debate is the ultimate potlatch, demanding that we offer up something inside of ourselves without asking for something in return. Debate provides a few minutes carved out of lives that are otherwise consumed by pop-up ads, or email. When I think about the moments that I treasure in my life, few of them are moments of consumption. I don’t remember when I bought my television, but I remember with painful longing the last bicycle ride I took with friends.

Alongside the memories of moments with friends and in nature, I treasure a collection of moments in debate. Moments when I first learned about ideas, late nights in the squad room, the friendships that emerged, and watching my debaters grow and develop. The parts of the potlatch where humans draw out moments of freedom with each other are increasingly the only thing that keeps me interested in debate. Debord and the Situationists wanted people to take their initial offerings of the Potlatch and move them along into their own lives. We can do the same thing with debate. Almost all of us have debate memories that are deeply infused with the Potlatch-ethic. All it takes is for us to seek out and celebrate those moments, and our community will change. But these moments of time have to be

⁷ Debord was a committed life-long abuser of drugs and alcohol, and he certainly would have appreciated gifts of these sorts.

grappled away from the industrial-capitalist state with great gusto. We must be brave to crack open debate.⁸

In our own lives, we should strive to bring about the kinds of realizations that elicit revolutionary transformation. Snider's gaming does not bring us forward in direct revolutionary thinking. Rather, it encourages revolutionary thought and then focuses its power into the system of debate. The solution for Snider is not to continue looking for a way to explain and systematize debate but, rather, to embrace the confluence of potential meaning in debate and lunge forward. Debate should be about taking risks and creating new meaning out of our desires.

We should never sublimate our feral interests and instead should seek the highest level of meaning. Let us push gaming further. Let us find games that fulfill our revolutionary potential, take whatever moments we can for ourselves and try to push for as much change as we possibly can. In this case, perhaps it is not the game, but the players who have not yet made their move.

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⁸ We might wonder what people look like, living in a world defined by potlatch. Hussey quotes George Clutesi, who observed the last Vancouver Potlatch, as saying: "They lived from one day to the next, they accepted all things as they came. They spoke slowly, they took much time before uttering, before replying, before expressing an opinion" (Hussey, 2001, p. 86). The Potlatch elicited entire new ways of being, a fundamental transformation of ontology.

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